

Readings

Hide-and-Seek with God

By Mary Ann Moore

Once upon a time God said, "I'm bored because I don't have anything to do. I want to play with my friends." And because God is God, as soon as the words were spoken, God's friends were there. When God saw them all gathered, God said, "I've been bored because I haven't had anything to do. Let's play something."

"Good idea," said God's friends. "What shall we play?"

God thought for a minute and then said, "I know, let's play hide-and-seek!"

The friends all said, "Yay!" They knew that hide-and-seek with God was always exciting and different because God was the one who hid and God always thought of wonderful places to hide.

God's friends closed their eyes tight and counted to ten. When they opened their eyes, God wasn't there anymore. So they all went off to look for God.

One friend decided to look close on the earth and soon came to a meadow. As he was searching, he stopped to admire the tender new sprouts of green grass pushing their way up toward the sun. As he bent over to look more closely at the tender green, he realized there was something special and amazing and wonderful about it. So he jumped up and ran back to home base, calling out, "I found God! God is green and growing. I found God in the grass!"

Another one of God's friends decided to look for God in the night. She watched the sun go down, and heard the work-a-day noises stop, and saw the lights in the houses go out. As it got darker and the peaceful night wrapped itself around her, she listened very hard, and then she realized there was something special and amazing and wonderful about it. And when it was so still that she could see and hear nothing at all, she suddenly

jumped up and ran to home base, calling out, "I found God! God is dark and peaceful. I found God in the night!"

A third friend looked on the earth and felt the mystery of the grass growing toward the sun. He stayed and watched the night come on, and he felt the mystery of the darkness and the stars. He thought to himself, "These mysteries are special and amazing and wonderful." But when he finally came back to home base, he said, "I found wonderful mysteries but I'm not sure if I want to call them God."

A fourth friend decided to look for God where people were. He joined a group of people going home from work and went with them into the store where they bought food. He went with them back out on the street as they started for their homes. He was with them when someone came up and said, "Please, I'm very hungry. Could you share a little food with me?" The people readily agreed and as he watched them share, he realized there was something special and amazing and wonderful about those people. He turned around and ran to home base, calling out, "I found God! God is love and sharing. I found God in people who care for others!"

Finally, two more of God's friends, a boy and a girl, decided to look for God together. After a time, they came to a house and decided to look for God in the house. In the house they saw a room, and they looked for God in the room. In the room they saw a mirror, and they looked for God in the mirror. As they looked into the mirror, they realized there was something special and amazing and wonderful being reflected in it. They turned around and ran to home base, calling out, "We found God! We found God in us!"

At this God appeared again and said, "I had so much fun! Weren't those good hiding places? Some of you found me, others weren't sure, and others are still looking. That's OK because the most important thing is just to play the game. Let's do it again! I'm sure I can think of some other good hiding places." And they all called out, "Olly, olly, oxen free, free, free!" And the game started all over again.

Excerpt from What Kind Of God?
by Kabir

What
kind of God would God be
If God did not count the blinks
of your
eyes

and is in absolute awe of their movements?

What a God – what a God we
have.

Describing The Indescribable

I'm a bit embarrassed to admit this... I'm really in love with God. I know it's not cool. Still, I can't help myself. I'm really taken with the Divine. I think God is the most amazing, awe-inspiring, magnificent, tender, all-encompassing, holy, powerful ... uh thing, person, being, concept? This is part of the trouble with being excited about God, how in the world do I name the Creator of the Universe? What shall I call the Holy One? How do I even talk about the Source of Everything? You can see how this is a problem!

God is a difficult topic, at least in our Unitarian Universalist circles. In our non-creedal, pluralistic faith, we do not have a set and established belief about the Almighty. We are not even all on the same page about Divinity. Our congregations are made up of theists, agnostics, atheists, and those who are apathetic to the whole notion of a Supreme Being.

This morning I want to talk about God, with the caveat that I'm only going to scratch the surface of a very complex topic. I'm also going to focus on Western ideas about God. We won't get into the whole problem of God and the existence of evil. That could be a whole sermon series on theodicy.

It is generally held that the Western concept of Yahweh is introduced in the Hebrew book of Exodus, when Moses encounters a bush that is on fire, but not consumed. A voice coming from the burning bush tells Moses that he is being sent to the Pharaoh of Egypt to demand the release of the Jewish slaves. When Moses asks, "Whom shall I say sent me?" the voice responds "I Am Who I Am." Essentially, Jehovah is saying, "I'm too big to name or describe. I exist." This is not a lot of help, theologically speaking!

How do we even know about God? There are three primary ways we come to understand the Creator of the Universe: Experience, Revelation, and Reason. Experiences of God come in different forms.

- External and Universally Available - this could be looking up and seeing the wonder of a starry sky or marveling at the love and compassion shown between neighbors during a crisis. Anyone has access to these experiences.
- External and Private - such as coming upon a burning bush. An individual encounters the Everlasting through some outside event.

- Interior and Effable - meaning there is a personal thought, feeling, or experience and an individual can find words to talk about it. A person might say that they felt at one with the universe, or awash in a great wave of peace, or swimming in a sea of love. This might be a vision or a knowing. An individual partakes of the Divine.
- Interior and Ineffable - this time, there are no words to describe what one experiences. It's too mystical.

Revelation has to do with other people sharing their knowledge about God. Religion plays a big role here. There are sacred texts that speak about who God is, what God did, or what God does. They attempt to reveal to the reader information about a Higher Power.

Reason stems primarily from philosophy and theology. I had a blast researching the various philosophers and theologians. Some of it got very convoluted! The focus is on using logic to discern just what it means to refer to God. A quick example states that both philosophy and theology declare that God must be perfect and complete. If the Supreme Being were still growing and developing, then that being would not be complete. An incomplete God just doesn't make sense.

For many people, Nature, with a capital N, is the greatest testament to God. The majesty of the mountains, the unbridled power of the seas, the destructive fury of a hurricane and the persistent drive of a seedling tree growing up through a crack in the sidewalk all speak to the dynamic forces of the Divine. There is a wisdom and a rhythm to the natural world. Life and death and decay and new life. There is a charming reading called "Composting is my Religion" referencing the fact that in nature, nothing is wasted. The physical world is miraculous. Some believe that God is nature.

Theologically, there is a fine distinction to be made. If we understand that God is in everything, and that all together, all of creation, is the Holy, we call it Pantheism. God is in everything and all of it is God.

If we determine instead that God is bigger than everything all together, we call it Panentheism. Nature, the universe, all of it, is in the mind of God. Rather than God being in everything, everything is in God.

And a third category, just to add to the glossary, is the idea that God is separate from everything. The Creator is entirely beyond and above the physical universe. The belief that the Source of All created the world and the universe and set it all to running, and then stepped back and let it go is Deism. The Almighty made the universe to be self-sustaining and God does not intervene in human and worldly affairs. America's founding fathers were Deists and believed that they were responsible for bringing about justice and rightness in the world. God might be for them in the quest for self-governance, but God wouldn't interfere.

We can understand God by studying creation. Incidentally, science came about because of religion. When people believed that the gods were inconstant and arbitrary, the world was chaotic and random. When people began to believe that a single God was constant and reasonable, it made sense that creation was steady enough to examine and study. Good science and good theology are never antithetical!

Getting to know God by learning about nature is called Natural Theology. There is a lot to commend this approach. The power and awe-full-ness of storms and oceans, volcanoes and earthquakes point to the energy, strength, majesty and forcefulness of the Almighty. The order, beauty, and variety in nature point to these same traits in the Creator. All that is speaks to the wonder of God.

I have a favorite memory. I was in junior high, bored to tears in social studies class, when I noticed a teeny, tiny little bug on my paper. This insect was bright orange and it was no bigger than the point on a pin. I could barely make out its miniscule legs as it crawled up the page. As I watched it, it dawned on me that this little dot of a creature had just as much life in its impossibly small body as I had in all of me. It blew my mind. God, who made, the free-form clouds floating above the field, the massive tree in the school yard, the birds in that tree and me, also made this infinitesimally tiny insect. And that bug was just as alive as me. I was mesmerized.

God's bigness and otherness speaks to transcendence. God is in and through it all - in the clouds, the tree, the birds, me, and the bug.

God's immanence speaks to the closeness, the connection and the details. It's God knowing the number of hairs on our heads, the words we will say before we say them, (because we are so well known - not pre-destination) and God even knows about the sparrow that falls. The Holy is so great, nothing in the universe is alone. And the Holy is so small, even the tiny insect is graced by God. Some claim that the Ground of all Being is the space between the atoms.

So natural theology teaches us a great deal about the Creator and Sustainer of the Universe. However, we are also selective in what we take from the natural world. We pick and choose what nature we will use as an example of Yahweh. As a young child, I couldn't comprehend what it meant about God when I witnessed a mother hamster eat her babies. That was not a God I wanted to know.

When we talk about God, we have to talk about pronouns. Most of the time, God is referred to as "He." Yet God is a spirit, there is no gender. While many of the metaphors in scriptures and sacred writings are masculine, such as Father, Lord, and King, there are also many feminine metaphors, like Mother, Bride, Queen. The ancient Hebrew El Shaddai can be translated as "Almighty." It also means "Breast." There are also non-gendered metaphors: Rock, River, Eagle, Ocean, Light and so on.

The reason the word "He" has been used is because the language of ancient texts is gendered. Every word is assigned a gender; similar to Spanish or French today. The gender of a word is not necessarily linked to the sex of the object. In the old old Hebrew, the word for "He" was both the word for the male pronoun, and a gender neutral pronoun. "It" was not a word used in association with the Supreme Being since it seemed disrespectful.

Personally, I don't like calling God "He." I'd rather use the word "God" over and over, or use other names and synonyms. Language matters and it's too easy to make God into that great old man in the sky. A few years ago the book, The Shack by William Young presented God as a Black woman, with mixed reviews.

Many of our metaphors for the Higher Power are anthropomorphic. That makes sense. As we think about our relationship to the Divine, we use images from the relationships we know. Papa, Mama, Friend, Lover, Potter, Baker, Midwife, Counselor.

Some say that humans have created God in our image. Well, of course. We look at everything from our human point of view. We anthropomorphize dolphins and gladiolas. Just because we are ego-centric does not mean God does not exist. It does caution us to remember, it's not all about us.

As Unitarian Universalists, we aren't limited in our images of God. We're encouraged to choose words that have meaning for us and that deepen our own encounters with God.

One of my dear friends used to imagine "Grandmother God." When she had a particularly hard day, she pictured laying her head in "Grandmother God's" lap and having her hair stroked.

Another friend had been a midwife and believed that much of the Holy's work in her life was similar to the efforts of the midwife, being present, offering support, pushing her to do the tough things to bring about something new.

When we choose symbolic words about God that could also be words about creation, it is communicable. These are traits that can be shared. Loving, Powerful, Righteous, Holy, Wise are all words that could be applied to people and places and things. Incommunicable are attributes of God that can't be shared. Words that depict the limitlessness of the Divine are in this category: Eternal, Infinite, Omnipresent.

The Unity of All Perfections is close to this category. God is the pinnacle, the very essence of certain traits and in this vain, they can't be shared with humans. For example, God is Perfection itself, and Love itself, and Holiness, and Grandeur, and Mercy. By definition, no one is more perfect in one of these attributes than God.

The Westminster Shorter Catechism declares: "God is a spirit, Whose being, wisdom, power, holiness, justice, goodness, and truth are infinite, eternal, and unchangeable." This definition includes both the communicable and incommunicable. It also lines up with most theologies and philosophies.

Philosophy and theology also claim that being God requires that God is outside of time and space. Eternal, Infinite, not subject to the laws of time and space and the material world. God sees the future, because God is not stuck in time the way we are.

These “outside of” and “beyond” aspects of the Ground of Being lead us to the big four - Omnipresent - God is everywhere, all the time, and fully present. (Wow!). Omniscient - God knows everything and isn’t bound by time or location. Omnipotent - God is all powerful, there is nothing that can be done that God can’t do. (And we aren’t going to the question of can God make a rock so big God can’t lift it!) And Immutable - God doesn’t change, because God is perfect and does not need to get better. God’s complete.

Let me confuse things a little with an aside here. Both Process Theology and Open Theology say that God does change. Not in the sense of God needing to improve. Instead, God is so in love with and involved in creation that God is impacted by what happens. These two theologies challenge the concept of God as aloof, set apart and safe from creation. They postulate that the Almighty is in process with us and “has skin in the game.” I’m really attracted to this idea.

Contemporary Theology moves away from the communicable attributes of God and has a more esoteric approach. God is: The Ground of All Being, Being Itself, Consciousness, Reason Itself, Energy, Love, Light, Life and First Cause. Star Wars presented us with the idea of “The Force” and many people like this metaphor for God. The Pythagoreans believed numbers were the ultimate, divine substance of the universe. God equals beautiful math.

There are those who don’t appreciate the implication that God is a perfect concept. They insist that God is a person, just not located in space or time. However, I don’t see the conflict. It makes sense that Our Highest Self can be both. Remember, we are trying to describe the indescribable.

So what do we do with all this information about God? How we believe impacts how we live. The research studies I came across had interesting things to say about how one believes in God. The individual who understands the Almighty as a King, Judge, Lion, and Father will have a different experience than the person who thinks of God as Love and Light and Life. The more concrete the metaphor, the more stridently one believes about their version of God.

We are free, within this religion of ours, to change our beliefs about the Divine. We are not locked into a particular definition. All this information gives you more room to, yes, I will say it, create a God that makes sense to you. You are wise enough to choose an understanding of God that fits with your own needs, experiences and reasoning. You know not to create a great Santa Claus in the sky. You've been around long enough to know that doesn't work. You probably won't create a God that has a vested interest in which team wins the football game and who demonstrates blessings only through wealth and fame.

I like that we can be intentional about how we frame the Divine. We don't have to just believe what someone else has told us. One of the readings I came upon while researching this sermon used a refrain. The author would say, "I'm an atheist if it means believing" - and then he'd write some attribute of God that was nonsensical or petty or narrow, like "I am an atheist if believing in God means believing there is a great puppeteer in the sky and God has a reason for everything that happens." Then he says "But I believe in God if it means" - and here he'd write about something expansive or encouraging or good, like "But I believe in God if by God we mean that there is something bigger than us and we are ultimately being led towards love."

As you think about God, two questions you can ask yourself are 1) What do I need in a God I can believe in and 2) What does it mean if I believe such things?

Of course, you do not have to consider God at all. H.L. Mencken writes "Good God, how much reverence can you have for a supreme Being who finds it necessary to include such phenomena as phlegm and tooth decay in the divine system of creation?" (Adapted)

In closing, I'd like to offer you a few more metaphors for God.

God lives in the thin places.

God hangs out where there is suffering - like hospice, which is both ridiculously hard and unbearably holy at the same time.

God is the Process

God is that in which we live, move, and have our being.

God, who is in, among, and beyond us.

William Butler Yeats offers "Some people say there is a God: others say there is no God. The truth probably lies somewhere in between."

You decide. As for me, I'm going to stay crazy in love with the Divine.

Amen and Amen

